

Is Musk falling back to Earth?

It's a challenging time for the world's richest man, who sees his projects unraveling both in D.C. and out.

By MICHAEL WILNER

WASHINGTON — A Starship spun out of control in suborbital flight on Tuesday, failing to meet critical testing goals set by SpaceX in its plans for a mission to Mars. A poll released last week showed the national brand reputation for Tesla, once revered, had cratered. And later that same day, House Republicans passed a bill that would balloon the federal deficit.

It has been a challenging period for Elon Musk, the world's richest man, who not long ago thought he had conquered the private sector and could, in short order, do the same with the federal government. In just over four turbulent months, Musk risks his projects in both spheres unraveling.

On Wednesday night, Musk wrote on X that his time in the Trump administration was coming to an end. The Associated Press reported that a White House official confirmed that Musk is leaving.

Also Wednesday, a federal judge in Washington ruled in favor of 14 states challenging Musk's appointment as a temporary government employee, questioning whether any of his work for the Department of Government Efficiency — a White House advisory team that levied steep cuts across agencies — was constitutional.

"I thought there were problems," Musk said in a recent interview with the Washington Post, "but it sure is an uphill battle trying to improve things in D.C., to say the least."

Growing conflicts with Trump

Musk's role as an omnipresent advisor to President Trump began to wane weeks ago amid public backlash against DOGE's cuts to treasured government programs — including cancer research and the National Park Service — and after Trump bucked Musk's counsel on economic policy, launching a global trade war that jolted supply chains [See Musk, A7]



GINA FERAZZI Los Angeles Times

A REPORT found an 80% chance that 2024 will be surpassed as the warmest year on record by 2029.

An ever-hotter planet looms

By CORINNE PURTILL

As hot, dry and disastrous as the last few years have been, it appears that the chaos caused by a warming planet is just getting started.

Though the hottest year in nearly two centuries was recorded only last year, the world will probably shatter that record yet again by 2029, according to a new report from the World Meteorological Organization, the climate and weather arm of the United Nations.

There is a very good chance that average warming over the next five years will be more than 2.7 degrees Fahrenheit, or 1.5 degrees Celsius, above preindustrial levels, the cap established by the Paris Agreement to ward off the worst consequences

A new U.N. report warns of more frequent, intense natural disasters and chaotic climate 'whiplash'



MYUNG J. CHUN Los Angeles Times

RAPID SWINGS between wet-to-dry and dry-to-wet conditions are getting more common and intense.

of climate change. There's an even better chance that at least one of those years will be more than 2.7 degrees above the 1850 to 1900 average.

That means we can expect many more days when the weather feels freakish and far more natural disasters that cost people their homes, health or lives.

"It's pretty bleak," said Mike Flannigan, a fire scientist at Thompson Rivers University in British Columbia. "My fear is that [the coming years] will be even warmer than they suggest, and the impacts will continue to catch us by surprise and be more severe than we expect across the world, including the American West."

In the western U.S. states, including California, those effects most likely in [See Report, A12]

Pendulum swing seen in latest L.A. budget

A decision to cut police hiring in half and other actions offer signs of a progressive realignment underway at City Hall

By DAVID ZAHNISER

When tenant rights attorney Ysabel Jurado ran for Los Angeles City Council last year, she positioned herself as a potential fourth vote against Mayor Karen Bass' plan to hire more police officers.

While she was waging her campaign, the council's three-member super prog-

ressive bloc — Eunisses Hernandez, Nithya Raman and Hugo Soto-Martínez — voted against the mayor's budget, decrying the amount of money allocated for the Los Angeles Police Department. Jurado, who went on to unseat Councilmember Kevin de León, said she would have joined them, turning the 12-3 budget vote into an 11-4.

Turns out none of that

was necessary.

Last week, the council approved a \$14-billion annual budget that would cut police hiring in half, while sparing hundreds of other city workers from layoffs. Jurado, now on the council, praised the spending plan, then voted for it.

And this time around, the council members on the losing end of a 12-3 vote were those who occupy the body's

more moderate wing: Monica Rodriguez, Traci Park and John Lee.

The shift in budget votes from last year to now offers perhaps the strongest evidence of the political pendulum swing underway at City Hall. When other recent votes are added to the equation, the council chamber might even be undergoing a permanent realignment. [See City Hall, A12]

Trans kids in sports focus of inquiry

Federal officials are looking into whether California and others are violating the rights of cisgender girls.

By KEVIN RECTOR, BRITNY MEJIA AND HOWARD BLUME

The U.S. Justice Department has launched an investigation into whether California, its interscholastic sports federation and the Jurupa Unified School District are violating the civil rights of cisgender girls by allowing transgender students to compete in school sports, federal officials announced Wednesday.

The Justice Department is also throwing its support behind a pending lawsuit alleging similar violations of girls' rights in the Riverside Unified School District, said U.S. Atty. Bill Essayli, who oversees much of the Los Angeles region, and Assistant Atty. Gen. Harmeet Dhillon, who heads the Justice Department's Civil Rights Division.

Transgender track athletes have come under intense scrutiny in recent months in both Jurupa Valley and Riverside, with anti-LGBTQ+ activists attacking them on social media and screaming opposition to their competing at school meets.

Essayli and Dhillon, both Californians appointed under President Trump, have long fought against transgender rights in the state. Their announcements came one day after Trump threatened to withhold federal funding from California [See Transgender, A7]

U.S. plans to sue several colleges

UC, others face "massive lawsuits," says official leading antisemitism task force. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Deputy's felony charge reduced

Judge makes change even though a jury had convicted the lawman of assaulting a woman. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Will this art museum exist?

Despite a foundation's proclamation, the future of a Joshua Tree project is unclear. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Flagship retail store to rebuild

Elyse Walker returns to Palisades Village as developer Rick Caruso restores shopping site after fire. **BUSINESS, A8**

Weather

Turning sunny. L.A. Basin: 78/61. **B6**

Markets A9

Opinion Voices A10

For the latest news, go to latimes.com.



7 85944 00200 5



BRIAN VAN DER BRUG Los Angeles Times

ENTIRE blocks of Altadena homes were destroyed by the Eaton fire and 18 lives were lost. Two lawsuits by homeowners focus on that blaze and the Palisades fire.

Did insurers collude to force homeowners onto state's FAIR Plan?

Two L.A. County lawsuits accuse dozens of firms of dropping policyholders and benefiting from it.

By LAURENCE DARMIENTO

The firestorms that swept through Pacific Palisades, Altadena and other communities Jan. 7 not only devastated thousands of homeowners but highlighted a giant problem: the growth of the state's insurer

of last resort. The California FAIR Plan Assn. offers policies that cover less, but can often be expensive.

Now, California home insurers are facing twin lawsuits filed by homeowners who accuse them of colluding over the last several years to force them into the plan in order to profit from the higher premiums while reducing their liabilities in the event of a catastrophe — just what the lawsuits allege happened after the fires. The result, according to one suit, is the insurers "collectively reaped a windfall worth billions of dollars."

[See Insurers, A9]



Every story. Every section. Every feature.

Subscribers get unlimited app access. Download now.

